

Journeyways

Facilitator's guide

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This guide is for the person who brings JOURNEYWAYS to a table: a friend hosting a game night, a teacher, a community worker running a workshop, or a researcher running a study session.

Facilitating JOURNEYWAYS is less about teaching rules and more about holding space. The players make the story; you make it easy, safe and unhurried for them to do so.

Read the Game Rules manual first, and keep it at hand. This guide does not repeat the rules; it explains how to open, guide, end and extend a session around them.

> **The one rule that matters:** every rule in JOURNEYWAYS can be bent or broken, by anyone, at any moment, as long as the group is okay with it. Breaking a rule is not a failure of the game; it is the game working.





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Your role

As the facilitator you wear a few hats at once:

- **Host.** You welcome people, set up the table and make the room feel safe and unhurried.
- **Guide.** You explain how to play, and above all that the rules are only a starting point. New players often need permission before they believe they can change the game.
- **Keeper of the space.** You introduce the safety tools, notice when someone is uncomfortable, and pause the game when it needs a pause.
- **Timekeeper.** You keep an eye on the clock so the session can end gently instead of being cut short.

You don't play

The facilitator is not a player at the table. You do not create a character, pick cards or direct the story. Staying outside the game lets you watch the whole table, step in when needed, and keep the space for everyone equally.

You can still model the spirit of the game: answer questions with "what would you like to happen?", welcome odd ideas, and show that nothing is wrong here.

Before the session

The facilitator's kit

- One complete copy of the game, and the Game Rules manual.
- One player booklet per player, plus a spare.
- Plenty of sticky notes (Post-it size), so players can make new places on the spot.
- Pens, pencils and a few colours.
- A small bag of assorted playing pieces (see the next page).
- Water and simple snacks. They help the slow pace.

All the game components can be found and downloaded at journeyways.ca/components

The space and the time

- A quiet room with steady, comfortable light.
- A big enough table: the map grows, and 1.5 m by 1.5 m (about 5 by 5 feet) is comfortable.
- Seats for every player, and a place for you slightly apart.
- Check access ahead of time (step-free entry, washrooms) and ask players about any needs.
- Plan about 2 to 2.5 hours in total (arrival, opening, character creation, play and a closing conversation), or more if the game runs long. We recommend 1 to 1.5 hours of play at most, but a session can be as long or as short as the players want. JOURNEYWAYS is for 1 to 6 players, plus you. If more people want to play, use a second game set.

From a playtest: one session was planned for an hour of play, and the players asked to keep going for another half hour. Leave some slack in your plan.

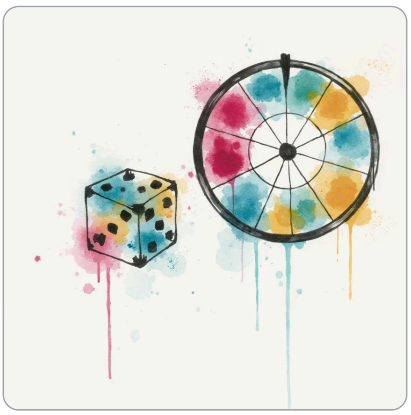
Playing pieces

Each player needs something to stand on the map. The player booklet includes a tear-out piece, but players can use **anything they like**: a ring, a coin, a button, a shell, a pebble, a piece borrowed from another game, a tiny toy.

The only limits are that the piece is not offensive and the group is okay with it. Choosing a piece is often the first small act of self-expression in the game, so give it a moment.

A few days before the session, invite players to bring a small object they would like to play with. Many enjoy choosing something personal.

> **Bring options.** Keep a small bag of assorted, cheap pieces: buttons, beads, old game pieces, keys, dice, marbles, bottle caps. Nothing fancy. Lay them out on the table and let players choose, swap or bring their own.



Opening the session

Let people arrive, settle and look at the materials. When everyone is ready, speak briefly to the whole table. Here is an introduction you can adapt into your own words, or use as it is:

> *Welcome, and thank you for being here. Today we're playing JOURNEYWAYS, a board game about becoming. Nobody wins and nobody loses. Each of you will grow a character and a story, one place and one card at a time, and write or doodle that journey in your booklet.*
>
> *Together we build a map out of tiles. On your turn you explore: add a place to the map, or make a new one on a sticky note, then move your piece. Then you pick a card and either do what it says or write about it in your journal. The game ends when the fifth black card turns up. I'll walk us through the first turn.*
>
> *The rules are loose, on purpose. They are a starting point, not a test. Any rule can be bent or broken, by anyone, at any time, as long as the group is okay with it. Want to put a tile somewhere strange, or change how something works? Just ask the table. Turns aren't rigid either: play when you feel ready, or sit one out.*
>
> *What you write is yours. Nobody has to read their journal aloud or explain it. If you want to share, we'd love to hear it; if not, that's completely fine.*
>
> *You can opt out of anything, at any time: skip a card, a prompt, a turn or a question, take a break, or leave. You don't need a reason; just say so. Is there any topic you'd rather not see in the game at all, or only mentioned in passing? Tell the group, or tell me privately.*
>
> *I'm not playing; I'm here to keep things comfortable and on time. We have about two hours. Any questions before we begin?*

Then lay out the playing pieces and let everyone choose one.

Safety tools

JOURNEYWAYS can touch personal ground: identity, memory, loss, the body. These tools help everyone feel free to go deep, because they know they can step back.

Opt out, any time

Anyone can skip a card, a prompt, a turn or a question, or leave the table, without explaining why. No signal or tool is needed: they just say so. Say this at the start and mean it.

Lines and veils

Before play, ask the group for **lines**, topics that will not appear at all, and **veils**, topics that can happen but stay off-page, mentioned without detail. Anyone can add one privately to you. Write them on a sticky note everyone can see.

Check-ins

Pause now and then to ask how people are doing (see During play).

Starting the game

1. **Character creation (10 to 20 minutes, or more if players ask for it).** Each player opens their booklet at the character sheet and answers the prompts. Some players write a lot, some a word or two; both are fine. It is good not to linger too long on this phase: the character keeps growing during play.
2. **Set up the table** together, following the Game Rules: shuffle the cards and the tiles into piles, and place the first tile.
3. **Choose who starts and a rough turn order.** Keep it loose. Turns are not rigid: anyone can play when they feel ready, or sit a turn out.
4. **Place the pieces** on the first tile.
5. **Begin.** Walk the first player through one turn (Explore, Pick, Reflect) out loud, then step back.

> Use the word **pick** for cards and tiles, not “draw”. In JOURNEYWAYS, drawing means illustrating: a blank tile, a sticky note, a doodle in the journal.



During play

Once the game is going, your job is mostly to watch and keep the space. Let silences happen; reflection takes time. Answer rules questions with an invitation more than a ruling: “what feels right to the group?”

When players break the rules

Celebrate it. When someone proposes a change (placing a tile somewhere odd, inventing a new place, ignoring a pile), ask the table if everyone is okay with it, then carry on. The change can last one turn or the whole game. If one player is not okay, the group finds another way.

Cards are open to change too. A player can adapt the card they pick: change what it says, read it their own way, ignore the text and go by the image alone, or make up content on the spot. The change does not need to last beyond that moment.

Check-ins

Every so often, especially after a heavy card or a long silence, pause and ask the table how people are doing. Keep it light: “want to keep going, take a break, or change something?” Breaks are part of the game.



Ending the game

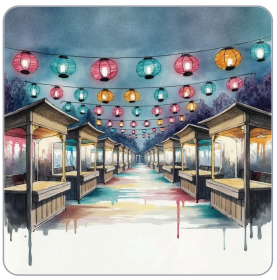
By default the game ends when the fifth **Black** card is picked. The group can end earlier or later, use a timer instead, or stop when a story feels complete. Give a gentle warning about ten minutes before you need to wrap up.

When play ends, give players a few quiet minutes to write a last journal entry and fill in the character sheet at the end of their booklet: what changed, and what stayed the same. Used cards can be discarded or kept as a log of the journey.

The closing conversation

Spend 15 to 25 minutes together. Sharing stays optional. Some questions that work:

- What did you notice about your character, or about yourself?
- What felt good? What got in the way?
- Which rule did you break, or wish you had? Should it become part of the game?





Extending the game

A session can run longer, or carry on across several sessions:

- **Raise the countdown.** End at the sixth, seventh or tenth **Black** card instead of the fifth.
- **Shuffle back.** When the piles run low, shuffle the discarded cards back in.
- **Add new places.** Players can make new tiles on sticky notes, during play or between sessions, and add them to the map.
- **Continue next time.** Photograph the map before you pack it away, keep the journals and any kept cards, and note where each piece stood. Next session, rebuild the map and pick up where you left off. Characters and stories keep growing between sessions.





Research sessions

When a session is part of a research study, the study's approved protocol comes first. What follows are only general recommendations: each study has its own protocols, and those are what govern the session.

- **Informed consent.** Share the consent form ahead of time if you can, go through it at the start, answer questions, and collect signatures before anything is recorded.
- **Recording.** Record only what the consent form allows. Photograph only people who signed the waiver; photograph the table, not faces, by default.
- **Observation notes.** Write notes during play, referring to people by a pseudonym or code, never their name.
- **Booklets.** If the study keeps the booklets, players must know this before they write in them.
- **Withdrawal.** Anyone can withdraw, during or after the session, as set out in the consent form.

The safety tools, the loose rules and the optional sharing apply exactly as in any other session.



Notes

For your thoughts, sketches, and discoveries.

Journeyways

A board game about becoming.

Website

www.journeyways.ca

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